Chapter 5

Lashing Waves

On the midnight of 14/15 August 1947, when Jawaharlal Nehru, the first Prime Minister of the Indian Dominion was reading out his famous ‘Tryst with Destiny’ speech in Parliament House in New Delhi, what was happening in Maharaja Hari Singh’s palace in Jammu and Kashmir?

Hari Singh’s Dilemma

The Maharaja was in a quandary. After he had sacked his Prime Minister, Ram Chandra Kak, on 11 August 1947, he discovered that both the IG Police, Richard Powell IP, and the Commander-in-chief of Jammu and Kashmir State Forces, Maj. Gen. H. L. Scott, were a party to helping Kak and his British wife Margaret escape Srinagar.[1] If the Maharaja could not trust his own Police Chief and Commander, how was he going to preserve the writ of his rule? It is no surprise that hardly a month later, on 24 September 1947, Maj. Gen. Scott relinquished his command. In a few weeks, the Maharaja sacked IG Police Powell, days before the Pathan invaders reached the borders of the state. It is believed that the Maharaja had received intelligence reports about Powell’s involvement with his Pakistani counterparts in Muzaffarabad and Rawalpindi. Upon his sacking, Powell left for Rawalpindi via Muzaffarabad, and in no time at all, he allegedly joined the Pakistan security apparatus as an advisor.